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Brigitte Bardot, Legendary French Film Icon Dies at 91

Brigitte Bardot, one of the most iconic figures of 20th-century cinema and a defining symbol of French culture, has died at the age of 91, her long-time animal welfare foundation announced. Bardot, whose beauty and magnetism revolutionised international screen stardom in the 1950s and 1960s, passed away at her beloved home in Saint-Tropez on December 28, 2025, after a battle with cancer, her husband Bernard d’Ormale confirmed to the press.

1934, in Paris, Bardot first captured global attention with her breakout role in *And God Created Woman*. >>>> **Pg 7**

PM Modi Calls on Gen-Z and Gen-Alpha to Lead Nation-Building with Discipline, Confidence and Innovation, Urges Youth to Dream Big for Realising Viksit Bharat Vision

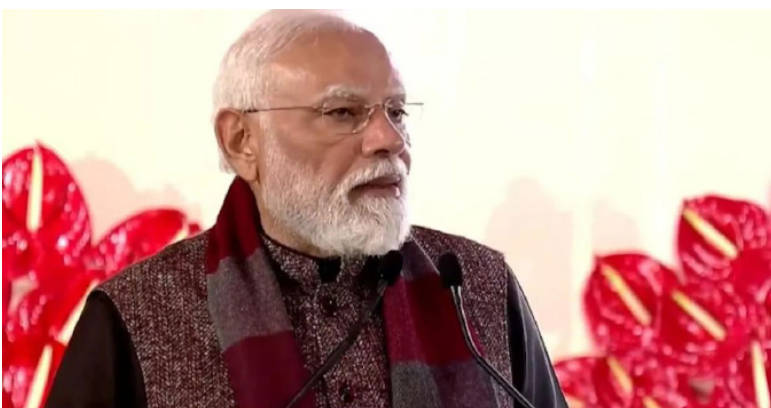
Samridhi

Highlighting the vast opportunities emerging across sectors, Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed strong faith in the abilities and confidence of Gen-Z, urging young Indians to contribute to nation-building through hard work and discipline to realise the vision of Viksit Bharat.

“So many young people associated with the organisation are present here. In a way, all of you are ‘Gen-Z’, ‘Gen-Alpha’. Your generation will take India to the goal of a developed India. I see and understand Gen-Z’s capabilities and your confidence, and therefore, I have great faith in you. Age doesn’t determine who is small

or who is big. You become big through your deeds and achievements. Even at a young age, you can do such work that others draw inspiration from you,” PM Modi said.

PM Modi advised youths not to be distracted by “short-term popularity,” encouraging them to learn from great personalities who contributed to nation-building. “You need to stay focused, and for that, it’s essential that you don’t get caught up in the glitz and glamour of short-term popularity. You must learn from your ideals, learn from the great personalities of the country. You shouldn’t consider your success as limited only to yourself.



Your goal should be that your success becomes the success of the nation,” he said.

Noting that the NDA-led government has overcome the atmosphere of “despair and hopelessness” with initiatives that transformed India, PM Modi shared that now the youth have the opportunity to make progress in every field. “Previously,

young people were even afraid to dream, because the old systems had created an environment where it seemed nothing good could ever happen. An atmosphere of despair and hopelessness prevailed everywhere. People even started to think, “What’s the point of working hard?” But today, the country seeks out talent and provides them with a platform. The

strength of 1.4 billion countrymen is behind their dreams,” he said.

“Thanks to the success of Digital India, you have the power of the internet. You have resources for learning. For those who want to enter the fields of science, technology, and startups, there are missions like Start-up India. For those excelling in sports, there is the Khelo In-

dia mission,” he added. Referring to Veer Sahibzadas, PM Modi encouraged youths to dream big, work hard, and never let their confidence waver. “The veer Sahibzadas did not consider how difficult the path was.

They only considered whether the path was right or not. Today, we need that same spirit. This is what I expect from the youth of India - dream big, work hard, and never let your confidence waver. India’s future will be bright only if the future of its children and youth is bright.

Their courage, their talent, and their dedication will guide the nation’s progress,” he said. “Across the

country, millions of children are engaging in innovation and research at Atal Tinkering Labs. Children are being introduced to robotics, AI, sustainability, and design thinking in their schools. Along with all these efforts, the National Education Policy provides the option of education in the mother tongue. This is making learning easier for children and helping them understand subjects more easily,” he added.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on January 9, 2022, announced that December 26 would be observed as ‘Veer Baal Diwas’ to commemorate the martyrdom of the sons of Sri Guru Gobind Singh Ji.

Over 1,500 Cyclists Join Fit India Cycle Anniversary Event, Turning Puducherry’s Rock Beach into Fitness Carnival

Samridhi

On December 21, 2025, over 1500 cyclists, representing people from all walks of life, including school students, NaMo Cycling Clubs, students from Puducherry University, and more turned the scenic Rock Beach in Puducherry into a vibrant festival of fitness; reflecting the growing national importance of the movement and the rise of cycling in the nation.

Padma Bhushan and Khel Ratna awardees P R Sreejesh and Sharath Kamal rode alongside the youth, further inspiring participants to embrace sports and fitness. In every single aspect, the landmark first anniversary edition of the Fit India Sundays on Cycle in Puducherry turned into a complete fitness carnival zone as multiple fun games and activities like Zumba, carrom, chess, mallakhamb, silambam, yoga, rope skipping, also took centre stage. Co-incidentally, also with

December 21 being the World Meditation Day, the message was collectively sent out that Fitness is indeed, Meditation in Motion!

The morning gathering in Puducherry today also consisted the Lieutenant Governor K. Kailashnathan, Chief Minister N. Rangasamy, Legislative Assembly Speaker R. Selvam, and Puducherry Home Minister A. Namassivayam, and other distinguished government officials, besides the presence of Hon’ble Union Sports Minister Dr. Mansukh Mandaviya – who flagged off the very first event in New Delhi a year back.

Addressing the gathering, Dr. Mandaviya explained how Fit India Sundays on Cycle has evolved from a modest beginning into a nationwide people’s movement. “When we started this initiative a year ago, it was organised at just five locations with about 500 participants. Today, more than 10,000 locations across the coun-



try take part every Sunday, with over 10 lakh citizens joining regularly. It has become a passion, a culture and a powerful solution for pollution. Hon’ble Prime Minister Narendra Modi has also helped in turning this movement into a nationwide fight against obesity,” he said.

Lieutenant Governor, Puducherry, K. Kailashnathan described the initiative as a timely message for society. “Dr. Mandaviya’s own village in Bhavnagar Gujarat, consists of 4000 people only. And everyone there commutes in a cycle, no other two-wheeler or four-wheelers. As citizens, we often don’t realise how small life-

style changes can collectively make a big difference for the environment, especially in terms of reducing the carbon footprint,” he said. Puducherry Chief Minister N. Rangasamy praised the Fit India Movement for promoting accessible fitness. “Cycling is one of the easiest and most effective ways to stay healthy. Only when our body is fit can we achieve our goals in life. I truly appreciate the Prime Minister’s vision behind the entire Fit India movement,” he said.

Simultaneously held in more than 10000 locations of the country today, Sports Authority of India and Khelo India centres across Hazaribagh, Kargil,

Patiala, Lucknow, Gollaghat, Rajnandgaon in Chattisgarh, Hissar, Tinsukia, Visakhapatnam, Kashipur in Uttarakhand, Cuttack, and more organised the events with various Banks across the country, being the special partners. The celebs gathering also included Arjuna Awardee archers Jyothi Surekha and Abhishek Verma from SAI Sonapat. A major impetus has been added to Sundays on Cycle by NaMo Fit India Cycling clubs and My Bharat volunteers who have been a key part of the campaign.

The morning’s event in Puducherry also saw the launch of the much-awaited Fit India Mobile App Carbon Credit Incentivization, boosting Cycling enthusiasts. Three cyclists who earned the highest carbon credits were felicitated during the event - Bharatbhai Parmar, Shashikant Veerkar, and Govind Singh. Citizens can cycle and earn carbon credits, which can be redeemed later.

Indian Railways Deploys AI Systems to Prevent Wildlife Deaths

Samridhi

Indian Railways has strengthened its Artificial Intelligence-based safety framework to protect wildlife on railway tracks, particularly in forest and elephant corridor regions. The enhanced system aims to reduce collisions involving elephants, lions and tigers by providing advance alerts to train crews, marking a significant step in integrating technology with wildlife conservation. Indian Railways has deployed AI-enabled cameras along vulnerable track sections to detect the presence of large animals. These systems alert loco pilots nearly 500 metres in advance, allowing sufficient time to slow down or halt trains. The initiative is designed to minimise accidents involving wildlife while ensuring safer train operations in ecologically sensitive zones. A key component of the initiative is the AI-enabled Intrusion Detection System based on a Distributed Acoustic System. This technology detects vibrations and move-



ments associated with elephants near tracks. The system has been successfully implemented across 141 route kilometres under the Northeast Frontier Railway, a region prone to frequent elephant movement and past train-animal collisions. Encouraged by its performance, Indian Railways has awarded additional tenders to extend the system over 981 more route kilometres. With this expansion, total coverage will increase to 1,122 route kilometres across the network. The system generates real-time alerts for loco pilots, station masters and control rooms, enabling coordinated and timely preventive action. The initiative reflects Indian Railways’ broader effort to balance infrastructure conservation goals.

expansion with environmental responsibility. By leveraging AI and real-time monitoring, the Indian Railways aims to protect endangered wildlife, reduce human-animal conflict, and promote sustainable rail operations in forested and biodiversity-rich regions. In addition to AI-based monitoring, Indian Railways has also adopted complementary measures such as speed restrictions in identified wildlife corridors, deployment of forest department personnel for joint patrolling, and installation of signage to alert train drivers in high-risk zones. The Railways has reiterated its commitment to scaling up technology-driven solutions as part of its long-term sustainable conservation goals.

Supreme Court Initiates Sua Motu Review on Need for Single Special Court in Delhi-NCR to Tackle Terror and Organised Crimes

Samridhi

On December 16, 2025, the Supreme Court initiated suo motu proceedings to examine the need for consolidating trials in terror and other grave offences before a single court in the Delhi-NCR, warning that gaps in the existing legal architecture were allowing “hardened criminals” to exploit jurisdictional overlaps and delay trials to their advantage.

Taking Notice on its own motion, a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joy-malya Bagchi noted that organised offenders frequently move across cities within

the National Capital Region (NCR) sometimes just a few kilometers apart, to trigger jurisdictional complications, resulting in fragmented investigations, multiple courts assuming jurisdiction and prolonged trials.” The eventual benefit goes to the hardened criminals, who may not be in the interest of society or the nation,” noted the bench in its order, stressing that the issue warranted serious consideration, including whether effective legislation was required to ensure optimal use of the existing legal framework. The court significantly acted as it marks a shift from adjudicating individual bail



pleas to addressing a systemic flaw affecting the prosecution of terror, organised crime and other serious offences, where delay itself becomes a tactical advantage for accused persons.

During the hearing, the bench questioned why Parliament had not enacted a jurisdictional framework for

the NCR similar to the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act, which grants police special powers like surveillance and intercepting digital communications to tackle hardened criminals or syndicates.” These hardened criminals commit a crime in Delhi, move to Gurugram, then to Ghaziabad and back to Delhi.

Why cannot there be legislation which handles the jurisdictional aspect like MCOCA?" the court asked. When Additional Solicitor General SD Sanjay pointed out that MCOCA was applicable to Delhi, the bench pressed further, asking why a law could not be crafted to cover the entire NCR. It cited scenarios where offences occur near inter-state borders and questioned why the law could not provide that a designated court in Delhi would retain jurisdiction in such cases."This is a legislative exercise. The court also flagged the paradox of different special courts operating in close proximity.

Bengal Sports Minister Resigns Post Chaos At Messi's Event

Samridhi

West Bengal Sports Minister Aroop Biswas has resigned amid mounting criticism over the alleged mismanagement of football icon Lionel Messi's event at Salt Lake Stadium. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee accepted his resignation on December 16, 2025, and decided to retain charge of the sports portfolio for the time being, a senior Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader said.

Biswas, however, will continue to hold charge of the state's power department. He had written to the Chief Minister requesting to be relieved of his responsibilities as Sports Minister. Meanwhile,

acting on the initial report of a committee set up by the CM to probe the incident, the TMC government issued show-cause notices to director general of police Rajeev Kumar, Bidhannagar police commissioner Mukesh Kumar, and state sports secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, asking them to explain within 24 hours why the situation spiralled out of control. Officials aware of the matter said the CRPF flagged security breaches after crowds swarmed Messi. "For 15 minutes, the CRPF had to form a ring around Messi and Luis Suárez and Rodrigo De Paul as crowds pressed against the cordon despite loudspeaker warn-

ings. Rising unruliness forced organisers to escort the players off the ground,” an official said. The opposition BJP targeted the TMC over the incident. Leader of the opposition in assembly Suwendu Adhikari said, “The disciplinary actions are an eyewash. Biswas and fire services minister Sujit Bose should be arrested.” TMC spokesperson Kunal Ghosh countered the allegation, saying such accountability was possible only under Mamata Banerjee’s leadership. “The CM has performed Raj Dharma by taking action against the officers. Ghosh added.

Pilot rest norms waiver only for 6 months' says DGCA to ED Raids Five Locations Linked to 'Manipur State Council' Delhi High Court

Samridhi

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) on Tuesday (December 16, 2025) told the Delhi High Court that it will ensure IndiGo implements the new pilot rest and duty norms expeditiously, despite the regulator granting the airline an exemption until February 10. DGCA told the Delhi high court that all variations and relaxations granted to airlines from the new pilot fatigue management norms will end within “six months,” as the regulator works to ensure full compliance with the Civil Aviation Requirement (CAR) on Flight Duty Time

Limitation (FDTL) issued in 2024. Appearing before a bench of justice Amit Sharma, on a contempt plea moved by pilot unions, the DGCA said that the exemptions granted to airlines were “temporary, routinely reviewed,” and issued without any commercial considerations. DGCA told the court that it had already asked all major airlines, including Air India and

IndiGo, to prepare for full implementation of the revised norms. Six months is the outer limit. “We have told all airlines, including IndiGo, to expedite compliance (with FDTL norms),” Said advocate Anjana Gosain, who appeared for the DGCA, told the Court. The court was hearing two petitions filed by the Federation of Indian Pilots (FIP) and the Indian Pilots Guild

(IPG), which have accused the DGCA of violating undertakings given to the court by allowing airlines to dilute rest and duty norms meant to address pilot fatigue. The HC hearing came close on the heels of IndiGo's unprecedented operational meltdown earlier this month, triggering thousands of flight cancellations and chaos across major airports. IndiGo, commanding over 60% of India's domestic aviation market cited pilot shortages, cascading delays from Airbus A320 software advisory, the enforcement of new FTDL fatigue rules and an aggressive winter schedule since October 26.

Samridhi

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED) on Tuesday (December 16 2025) conducted searches against two persons, Yambem Biren and Narengbam Samarjit, who presented themselves to be self-styled “Chief Minister” and “External Affairs & Defence Minister” of the “Manipur State Council” respectively. The searches are being carried out on five premises in Imphal related to the accused who are the key persons of Salai Group of Companies, an agency official said. They are being investigated as part of a money laundering investigation in connection with a case over

collecting more than 50 crore worth funds from the public in the name of an investment scheme. According to the agency, the investigation relates to the collection of more than 50 crore from members of the public through an investment scheme that is now under scrutiny for possible financial irregularities. The searches were conducted as part of the ongoing inquiry into the source

and utilization of the funds, and to recover evidence linked to the alleged offence. Officials said that during the searches, financial documents, digital devices and other material relevant to the case were being examined. The ED is expected to question the accused and other associated persons as the probe progresses. The development comes amid rising concerns over fraudulent schemes

that exploit public trust by promising high returns, often under the guise of quasi-governmental or self-appointed organisations. The ED has stressed that claiming unwarranted political authority to solicit investments could attract serious legal consequences under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

Supreme Court Questions Panel in Allahabad HC Judge's Removal Case

Samridhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday (December 16, 2025) pointed out a significant procedural flaw in the ongoing parliamentary proceedings seeking the removal of Allahabad

High Court judge Justice Yashwant Varma, observing that the constitution of an inquiry committee may have violated provisions of the Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968. The court was hearing a petition filed by Justice Varma, who is at the centre of a controversy following the recovery of cash from his official residence in Delhi. A

bench comprising Justices Dipankar Datta and Augustine George Masih noted that Section 3(2) of the 1968 Act clearly mandates that when a motion for removal of a judge is introduced in both Houses of Parliament on the same day, no inquiry committee can be formed until the motion is admitted by both Houses. The

bench questioned how a committee could be constituted when the motion was admitted only in the Lok Sabha and was still pending in the Rajya Sabha. Justice Varma's counsel, senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, argued that the Lok Sabha Speaker's decision to unilaterally appoint a three-member inquiry committee was con-

trary to the law. He pointed out that the Act requires a joint committee to be constituted only after both Houses admit the motion, with the Speaker of the Lok Sabha and the Chairman of the Rajya Sabha acting together.

The motion seeking Justice Varma's removal was introduced in both Houses on July 21, but while the Lok Sabha admitted it on August 12, the Rajya Sabha has not yet done so. Despite this, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla constituted a three-member panel, including Supreme Court judge Justice Ar-

avind Kumar, Madras High Court Chief Justice Manindra Mohan Shrivastava, and senior advocate V Bhaskar. The committee has since issued a notice asking Justice Varma to submit his written defense by January 12, 2026, and to appear in person on January 24. Raising concerns over parliamentary oversight, the Supreme Court bench remarked that Parliament has experienced legal experts and questioned how such an apparent statutory lapse occurred. The court also sought responses from the Lok Sabha Speaker's office and the secretaries general of both Houses on the issue.

Justice Varma has challenged the legality of the inquiry, describing the committee as “coram non jure”, meaning a body lacking jurisdiction. He has argued that proceedings for removal of a constitutional court judge are not routine departmental inquiries and require strict adherence to constitutional and statutory safeguards under Articles 124 and 217. The Supreme Court has issued notice on the petition and scheduled further hearing in January, indicating that the legality of the impeachment process itself may come under deeper judicial scrutiny.

Aravalli Hills HC hearing: SC stays order on new definition of Aravalli hills

The Supreme Court on December 29, put on stay its previous order on new definition of Aravalli Hills, and also ordered for a new expert panel to examine the issue. The earlier order of '100 metre' rule led to widespread criticism. Hearing a *Suo Moto* case on the matter, a bench led by the Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, "put in abeyance" its earlier decision (issued on November 20) to accept the Central Environment Ministry's definition of Aravalli Hills and Aravalli Range. The top court has also issued notice

Russia’s War Funding Hit as Falling Oil Prices, Sanctions and Shipping Hurdles Cut Export Revenues

Ananya Manchanda

Russia’s ability to finance its war effort is coming under increasing pressure as a sharp fall in oil prices and logistical challenges hit the value of its crude exports, despite steady flows of oil to global markets. According to recent reports, Moscow’s energy revenues along the backbone of its economy and military spending have dropped to their lowest levels in nearly three years, weakening the Kremlin’s financial cushion. Data compiled from shipping and trade analytics indicate that Russia’s average crude prices declined significantly in early Decem-

ber, dragged down by weak global demand, ample supply, and tighter enforcement of Western sanctions.

Although Russia continues to ship millions of barrels of oil each day, the revenue earned per barrel has fallen sharply, reducing overall export earnings. Analysts say this combination of stable vol-

umes and falling prices is proving particularly damaging to Moscow’s finances. One of the biggest challenges Russia faces is the growing complexity of transporting its oil. Since the invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Western nations have imposed sanctions, including a price cap on Russian crude, forcing Moscow to rely

heavily on a so-called “shadow fleet” of tankers. These vessels often operate without clear ownership, insurance, or tracking, increasing costs and risks associated with oil transportation. As a result, a rising number of shipments are delayed, rerouted, or left without a final destination for extended periods. Recent figures show that several Russian oil cargoes remain undelivered weeks after loading, particularly those shipped from western ports.

This has disrupted cash flows, as payments are often finalized only once oil reaches its destination. Tankers have been observed

loitering at sea or diverting to alternative ports in Asia, adding to shipping time and expenses. Russia’s crude exports to Asia, especially China and India, continue to dominate its oil trade. However, even these key buyers are benefiting from discounted prices.

With global oil markets well supplied, Asian refiners have greater leverage to demand cheaper Russian barrels. This has further compressed Moscow’s export earnings, even as volumes remain relatively high. On a four-week average basis, the gross value of Russia’s oil exports has fallen steeply, reflecting both lower prices and

slightly reduced shipments. Analysts note that this marks one of the weakest revenue periods since the early months of the war. The decline comes at a sensitive time for the Kremlin, as military spending remains elevated and domestic economic pressures are mounting. The revenue squeeze coincides with increased diplomatic and economic pressure from Europe and its allies. Western leaders have reiterated that Russia poses a longterm threat to security in the Euro-Atlantic region, reinforcing their commitment to sustaining sanctions and supporting Ukraine. These measures are designed to gradually erode Moscow’s capacity to fund its military operations.

Bondi Shooting: Police Say Suspects Acted Alone, No Overseas Links Found

Ananya Manchanda

Australian police are continuing their investigation into the Bondi shooting, which triggered a major security response in Sydney. The incident occurred in the busy Bondi area, leading to the temporary closure of surrounding locations as emergency services moved in. Police confirmed that those allegedly involved acted alone and were not part of any organised group. According to officials, there is no evidence linking the suspects to overseas extremist networks or training camps, including claims that they had travelled to the Philippines. Au-

thorities said checks of travel records, intelligence databases and financial information have not revealed any international connections. Police have urged the public to avoid spreading rumours and misinformation, stressing that the investigation is being guided by verified evidence. While inquiries are ongoing, officers said the shooting is currently being treated as an isolated incident, with no broader threat identified. Security has since been increased in the area to reassure residents and visitors. Community support services have also been made available to those affected by the incident.

Trump Announces \$1,776 Bonus for U.S. Troops Amid Cost-of-Living Concerns

Samridhi

In a high-profile speech from the White House, former President Donald Trump announced a \$1,776 bonus for members of the U.S. armed forces, presenting the move as a symbol of economic strength and appreciation for military service. Framing the payout as proof that the nation’s finances are on solid footing, Trump said the US has the resources to reward those who “protect American freedom at home and abroad.” The bonus figure, \$1,776, was deliberately chosen to echo the year of Amer-

ican independence, reinforcing Trump’s nationalist messaging and emphasis on patriotism. Addressing service members and their families, he described the bonus as a “well-earned recognition” for troops who have endured long deployments, global instability, and rising security challenges. “This is a strong economy, and a strong country takes care of its soldiers,” Trump said, adding that the bonus reflects his administration’s commitment to the military and national defense. However, the announcement comes at a time when many

Americans are struggling with persistent cost-of-living pressures. While inflation has eased from its peak, prices for everyday essentials such as groceries, housing, utilities, and transportation remain significantly higher than they were just a few years ago. For millions of households, wages have failed to keep pace with these increases, making basic expenses harder to manage. The timing of the announcement during the holiday season has also drawn attention. As families across the country budget for gifts, travel, and

celebrations, surveys show growing anxiety about personal finances. Rising rents, high mortgage rates, and expensive food items have left consumers feeling squeezed, even as political leaders highlight headline economic indicators. Trump’s speech emphasized macroeconomic strength, pointing to past growth and job creation. Yet recent data suggests the labor market has softened in meaningful ways. Hiring has slowed in several sectors, job openings have declined, and layoffs have increased modestly, particularly in technology, retail,

and manufacturing. Economists note that while the economy is not in crisis, it is showing clear signs of cooling. Critics argue that the troop bonus, though welcomed by service members, does little to address the broader financial stress facing civilians. Supporters praised the announcement, saying it demonstrates strong leadership. They argue that targeted bonuses are justified and that broader economic relief comes from pro-growth policies rather than short-term subsidies.

Taiwan Reports Chinese Aircraft Carrier Transit Through Taiwan Strait, Heightening Regional Tensions

Taiwan has said that a Chinese aircraft carrier sailed through the Taiwan Strait, underscoring what Taipei describes as a sustained campaign of military pressure by Beijing against the self-governed island. The development adds to already heightened tensions in the region, as China continues to assert its territorial claims over Taiwan, which it regards as part of its sovereign territory. In a statement, Taiwan’s Ministry of National Defense said the aircraft carrier was accompanied by other naval vessels as it transited the

strategically sensitive waterway separating Taiwan from mainland China. Taiwanese forces closely monitored the movement using naval and air assets, the ministry added, emphasizing that the situation remained under control. The Taiwan Strait is a crucial international shipping route and a long-standing geopolitical flashpoint. While China maintains that the strait falls under its jurisdiction, Taiwan and many Western nations consider it international waters. Chinese military transits through the area, particularly involving high-profile

assets such as aircraft carriers, are therefore closely scrutinized by regional governments and security analysts. Taiwanese authorities say such movements form part of a broader pattern of near-daily military activity by China around the island. This includes the frequent deployment of fighter jets, bombers, drones, and naval vessels near Taiwan’s air defense identification zone (ADIZ). Taipei views these actions as designed to intimidate the island’s democratically elected government and wear down its military readiness over time.

India and Israel Adopt Joint Roadmap to Deepen Strategic Partnership

Ananya Manchanda

India and Israel have made a new joint working plan for the year 2026 to make their relationship stronger. This decision was taken during External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar’s visit to Israel, where he met Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Sa’ar in Jerusalem. Both leaders discussed all areas of India–Israel relations and were happy that their partnership has grown steadily in the last 10 years. They said the relationship has now become a strong strategic partnership, which includes cooperation in diplomacy, defence, security, trade, technology and inno-

vation. After the meeting, Jaishankar said the talks were very useful and focused on the future. He said that the new joint plan will act like a roadmap to help both countries work together in 2026. He also said India and Israel want to increase cooperation in many fields such as business, start-ups, cyber security, agriculture,

water management and cultural exchanges. Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Sa’ar also said that India and Israel are building a partnership for the future. He added that the relationship has grown a lot in recent years and has great potential to help not only both countries but also global peace and innovation. He said Israel sees India

as an important partner and wants deeper cooperation. The two ministers also talked about major issues in the region and the world. The situation in Gaza was a major topic. India repeated its support for the Gaza Peace Plan, and Jaishankar said India hopes the plan will help create a long-lasting and peaceful solution. The ministers also exchanged views on broader global developments, including the need for stability in West Asia and respect for international law. They discussed humanitarian concerns, counter-terrorism cooperation, and the importance of dialogue through multilateral forums.

Digital Infrastructure and Pharmaceuticals Key as India, Jordan Deepen Bilateral Cooperation

Ananya Manchanda

India and Jordan have agreed to significantly strengthen bilateral ties with a focus on digital infrastructure, pharmaceuticals, infrastructure development and green mobility, as the two countries look to expand economic cooperation and unlock new growth opportunities. The renewed push came during high-level engagements led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Jordan’s King Abdullah II, highlighting a shared vision for future-oriented collaboration. Addressing the India–Jordan Business Forum in Amman, Prime Minister Modi emphasised the importance of

building on the historic trust between the two nations and translating it into concrete economic outcomes. He identified digital public infrastructure, pharmaceuticals, information technology, food parks and green mobility as priority areas where Indian expertise and Jordanian potential could come together to create mutual benefits.

Modi underlined that India’s digital frameworks, including platforms such as the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), could be integrated with Jordan’s systems to improve financial inclusion and efficiency. He said India’s experience in building scalable

and inclusive digital solutions could support Jordan’s development goals while opening new avenues for Indian companies in the region. Pharmaceuticals and healthcare emerged as another key pillar of cooperation. The Prime Minister noted that Indian companies are well positioned to manufacture medicines and medical devices in Jordan, which could serve as

a reliable hub for West Asia and Africa. Cooperation in health technology, medical education and research was also discussed as part of a broader effort to strengthen people-centric development.

Highlighting trade relations, Modi pointed out that India is Jordan’s third-largest trading partner, with bilateral trade standing at \$2.88 billion in 2023–24.

E20 Petrol: Policy Progress or Public Backlash?

Dr. Nivedita Sharma

scape is changing with the nationwide rollout of E20 petrol, which is petrol blended with 20% ethanol. This shift aims to reduce carbon emissions, decrease crude oil imports, and improve rural incomes. Announced as part of the ethanol blending program, E20 fuel has already replaced the earlier E10 blend at gas stations across the country. While government data highlights strategic gains, the policy has stirred public concern and sparked heated debate. Supporters of the E20 initiative argue that ethanol, mainly produced from sugarcane and other agricultural materials, offers several benefits. It improves energy security

by lowering India's reliance on imported crude, helps reduce emissions by replacing some fossil fuels, and provides a new income source for farmers in sugarcane and maize regions. The government's early achievement of its 20% blending goal, reached years ahead of schedule, has been celebrated as a success. However, the transition has faced criticism. A wave of complaints from vehicle owners, particularly on social media, has brought attention to issues like reduced fuel efficiency, engine wear in older vehicles, and overall performance problems. Surveys from independent sources showed that many owners of pre-2023 petrol vehicles reported lower mile-

age and higher maintenance costs after switching to E20 fuel. In response, the Centre has strongly defended the program. Officials have dismissed claims of engine damage or major mileage drops as “fear mongering” without credible scientific evidence. According to the government, thorough testing by automotive research agencies and manufacturers indicates that E20 causes only a slight reduction in fuel efficiency,

usually within a few percentage points, and does not harm vehicle health when proper materials and maintenance standards are followed. The Supreme Court recently clear out a petition that sought to reverse the policy or compel the provision of pure petrol (E0), thus backing the government's argument. This ruling highlighted the greater good of transitioning to cleaner fuel sources. However, this controversy also points to a

more serious underlying problem: consumer confidence and communication. Whereas policymakers are touting the long-term positive effects of this move in regards to the environment and the economy, it appears that the average car driver's concerns are not being addressed in due time. A better flow of information appears to be called for. Finally, the E20 controversy mirrors the eternal conflict between the progressive agenda and the realities on the ground. To ensure the success of the fuel transition process in the Indian context, the development of technology and the creation of public confidence are not mutually exclusive concepts.

The Dhurandhar Takeover: Grit, Glory, and the Death of the Glossy Spy

Mr. Sahil Dhall

The film industry loves a spectacle. Flying cars rule the box office, and gravity-defying stunts are usually a guarantee of returns. Aditya Dhar changed that. His latest film, *Dhurandhar*, signals a shift. The movie released on December 5. Immediately, records came crashing down. It crossed 850 crore worldwide, and it has been three weeks.

Momentum has not slowed. It is a phenomenon. Marketing didn't do this on its own. This is a perfect storm of success. Painstaking research. Astonishing production values. A casting coup. The actors are all individual. They are also strikingly similar. It's an intensity that rules them all. Dhurandhar refuses to treat espionage like a video game. Recent "spy universes" favor style.

Dhar chose the mud. The film lives in the unglamorous reality of intelligence work. The film borrows heavily from true events. The plot was seemingly motivated by early exploits of the National Security Adviser Ajit Doval. We follow the life of Hamza, played by Ranveer Singh, an undercover Indian agent who is embedded deep within Lyari in Karachi. You will

not find any high-octane car chases here, as Hamza dismantles a terror network from within. His silence is his weapon, his deception a shield. Critics call it “distress fiction.”

Psychological tension replaces the explosions. The screenplay embraces grey areas. Heroes look like villains. Duty blurs the lines. Survival blurs it more. Trade analysts call it "violent realism." The audience had grown tired of formulaic anxiety. They wanted patriotism without the screaming matches. Dhurandhar delivers.

The story gives the soul. Production design gives the body. And the visual scale is terrifying. There's a narrative set in claustrophobic alleys in Karachi. Reality was Bangkok, Thailand.

Production designer Saini S. Johray made the impossible happen. Mumbai was riddled with logistical nightmares, while political barriers were present in Pakistan.

The team packed their bags for Bangkok. A six-acre set rose from the ground, with five hundred Thai artisans hard at work-almost a second home for five hundred Indian craftsmen and artisans who joined them. Attention to detail borders on obsession: crumbling walls have specific textures, window grills are a perfect match for Lyari.

The set became a character, but it wasn't the only key presence in the film as invisible VFX did their magic. The film whisks the audience away to enemy territory, and the immersion just doesn't break.

The cinematography captures distinct palettes: golden for Amritsar, stark for Ladakh, with the wind whipping through the screen; “Karachi” in Bangkok is muggy. Neon lights spell out danger, and the visual language feels dark and moody; the theme, therefore, is that of isolation. The star cast drives the popularity. People can’t stop talking about it.

The actors are “very much similar.” This is the film’s core strength. They play opposing forces. They share a cinematic DNA. Ranveer Singh. Akshaye Khanna. R. Madhavan. Arjun Rampal. Sanjay Dutt. Rugged aesthetics bind them. A “masculine spine” holds the screen. Aditya Dhar has put together a powerhouse acting force. They exude power through their silence.

There is cohesion in the energy between the lead men. They play burdened men. They are dangerous. They are severely serious. Ranveer Singh dispels his high-on-energy persona. He gives a masterclass in restraint. He wears light-colored contact lenses. He broods. The role requires suppression. He mirrors his co-stars. He holds his own against veterans. He proves he can command the screen without a word.

Akshaye Khanna plays the antagonist, Rehman Dakait. He is the mirror image of Singh's intensity. He avoids loud theatrics. His calmness is unpredictable. It is chilling. He matches Singh beat-for-beat. Protagonist. Antagonist. Two sides of the same coin. Both intelligent

PHOTO OF THE MONTH



Caption: A splash of wild elegance in an urban oasis

The answers, half answers and non-answers of Bhupender Yadav on Aravalli Hills

- Dr. Rahul Kumar



Amidst a flurry of accusations, the government has a mountain to climb in order to clarify facts due to the growing outcry over the new definition of the Aravalli range. Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav has had a difficult time addressing worries about one of the oldest mountain ranges in the world over the past few days due to criticism from environmentalists and a social media storm claiming that large areas of the Aravalli hills may be opened for mining. The controversy started after the Supreme Court accepted a new definition of the Aravallis proposed by the government – only hills 100 meters above the local terrain will be considered as ‘Aravalli hills’. Two or more such hills within 500 metres of each other, along with the land between them, will be considered an Aravalli range. The hills span Rajasthan, Gujarat, Haryana and Delhi. Some straightforward yet poignant questions are at the center of the controversy: What precisely qualifies as the Aravalli range? How will the height be calculated? Will development and mining be permitted on 90% of the hills? On Monday, while addressing a press conference, minister Bhupender Yadav attempted to clarify the mountain of allegations. While the minister did give some satisfactory answers, he skirted a few key concerns regarding illegal mining. Some, however, turned out to be non-answers altogether.

ARAVALLI HILLS: CLAIMS AND CENTRE RESPONSE

Allegation: Mining and construction activities will be unchecked if the Aravallis are defined just by height. **Centre's defence:** The minister emphasized that until a scientific management plan is created and approved, no new mining leases will be granted anywhere in the Aravallis. According to him, only 0.19% of Aravallis's 1.44 lakh square kilometers could be mined. Under extraordinary and scientifically supported conditions, mining will be allowed even in that 0.19%. Additionally, he stated that exceptions might be made for purposes pertaining to atomic energy and strategic minerals. Yadav added that there would be no release of real estate sharks.

Satisfactory answer: The minister clearly mentioned that no new licences would be issued and mitigated fears of rampant mining in the ecologically sensitive region.

Allegation: Activists have raised fears over rampant illegal mining and the future scope of mining in the areas excluded under the 100-metre definition.

Centre's defence: The Environment minister said the new regulation was meant to curb illegal mining and allow "sustainable mining legally". He further said there would be strong enforcement against illegal operations through the use of drones.

Half answer: The minister failed to satisfactorily tackle questions on how illegal mining would be arrested and skirted a direct answer. Instead, he shifted the blame to Congress, alleging that the previous government allowed rampant illegal mining in Rajasthan.

Allegation: The biggest worry among activists is that the new definition will result in a very significant part of the range (nearly 90%) not being counted as Aravalli anymore. This will open doors to large-scale non-forest activities.

Centre's defence: At the press conference, Bhupender Yadav just said that only 217 sq km presently is eligible for mining. He also stressed that, as per the new definition, the entire landform, including the hill's base, slopes and associated features, rather than absolute height alone, will be protected.

Non-answer: The minister failed to provide a clear-cut answer on how many hills will be protected and how many will be affected. No definitive number was provided. In fact, a 2010 report by the Forest Survey of India revealed only 8% of about 12,000 hills in the range are above 100 metres. So, what will happen to the other 92% of the hills?

At the press conference, which was held amid an avalanche of criticisms and widespread protests in Delhi, Bhupender Yadav attempted to clarify some of the most contentious issues. However, while some of his answers were satisfactory, some appeared to be half-baked. Moreover, he also failed to adequately address concerns on illegal mining.

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No ‘Direct’ Link Between Air Pollution and Lung Disease, Says Union Health Minister

Kartik Chandel

In a deeply disturbing incident that has raised serious questions about blood safety and healthcare oversight, the Madhya Pradesh government on Friday, 19 December 2025, suspended three officials, including a doctor, after several children were reportedly infected with HIV due to alleged negligence in blood transfusion procedures.

The case has sparked widespread outrage and concern over the functioning, monitoring, and accountability of blood banks across the State. The incident came to light after health authorities confirmed

that a group of children undergoing regular blood transfusions for chronic medical conditions such as thalassemia tested positive for HIV. These children depend on frequent transfusions for survival, making strict adherence to blood screening protocols absolutely essential. Preliminary investigations indicated that contaminated blood may have been supplied to them, pointing towards serious lapses in mandatory testing and quality control measures. While the exact number of affected children has not been officially disclosed, sources within the Health Department revealed that multiple cases were detected during

routine medical examinations conducted over the past few weeks. The discovery prompted immediate administrative action, with the State Health Department suspending three individuals directly linked to the alleged negligence.

These include a medical officer responsible for supervising transfusion procedures, a

technician from a local blood bank involved in blood screening, and a senior staff member accused of failing to ensure compliance with safety protocols. State Health Minister and senior officials termed the incident “unacceptable” and deeply tragic,” stressing that such lapses endanger lives and erode public trust in the healthcare system.

They assured that strict and exemplary action would be taken against all those found guilty, adding that patient safety would remain the government’s top priority. To ensure a transparent and thorough probe, a high-level inquiry committee has been constituted to investigate how HIV-infected blood reached young patients despite the existence of mandatory screening protocols in all licensed blood banks. In a significant administrative step aimed at preventing similar incidents in the future, the government has ordered a comprehensive State-wide audit of all blood banks—public, private, and charitable.

India Braces for Surge in Cancer Cases

Kartik Chandel

In a sobering revelation regarding the country’s public health landscape, on Thursday, 18 December 2025, Union Minister of State Jitendra Singh informed the Rajya Sabha that India is projected to house approximately 2 million cancer patients by the year 2040. Currently, India ranks third globally in cancer prevalence, trailing only behind China and the United States. Speaking during the Question Hour, Singh highlighted a troubling shift in the nation’s epidemiological profile. While India was primarily plagued by communicable diseases until the 1980s, it now faces a “double burden” of both infectious and existing cases. The

non-communicable diseases (NCDs). The Minister noted that cancer is not only becoming more frequent but is also striking younger populations a trend mirrored in the rising rates of early-onset heart attacks. According to the Minister, the world currently sees approximately 20 million new cancer cases annually. India contributes significantly to this global figure, with an estimated 1.4 to 1.5 million existing cases. The

jump to 2 million by 2040 represents a nearly 33% increase in the disease burden over the next two decades. The Minister attributed this surge to several factors, including lifestyle changes and a demographic shift. “While 70% of our population is under the age of 40, the number of citizens aged 60 and above is also rising,” Singh explained. “This aging segment naturally adds to the overall disease burden.”

Over 30% Students in Odisha drop out before higher secondary: CAG Report

Anjali Yadav

More than 30% of students in Odisha schools are unable to continue their education beyond the secondary level, according to a report by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) tabled in the State Assembly on 9 December 2025. The report highlighted a sharp fall in the transition of students from secondary to higher-secondary classes. It stated that the transition rate was only 70.3%, which means nearly three out of every ten students either dropped out or failed to qualify for promotion to higher classes. The CAG also pointed out that the Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) at both secondary and

higher-secondary levels declined in Odisha during 2022–23 when compared to 2018–19. This trend was opposite to the national level, where enrolment improved during the same period. The report noted that the Odisha Education Department did not analyse the reasons behind this decline. The audit report also flagged discrepancies in official data. It found that in 2018–19, the transition rate from up-

per primary to secondary level in Bhadrak and Nuapada districts was shown as more than 100%, which is not possible. According to the report, between 2018 and 2023, around 1.5 lakh to 5.47 lakh students enrolled in Classes I to XI discontinued their education before moving to the next class. During this period, the dropout rate across different classes ranged between 3.12% and 7.26%. The CAG further stat-

ed that 61,487 out-of-school children in the age group of six to 18 years were not brought back into the formal education system during 2018–23. While the Odisha State Education Programme Authority did not study the reasons for the decline in the Net Enrolment Ratio (NER), the report suggested that weak measures to prevent dropouts, especially during the transition from upper primary to secondary level, along with poor school infrastructure and facilities, were likely reasons for the problem. The report called for urgent attention to address dropout rates and improve access and quality of education across the State.

Samridhi

On Friday, 19 December 2025, a new scientific study revealed that men in Delhi may be inhaling and retaining significantly higher levels of air pollutants in their lungs compared to women, raising fresh concerns about gender-specific health risks in one of the world’s most polluted cities. The findings come at a time when the national capital continues to battle hazardous air quality levels, with the Air Quality Index (AQI) frequently slipping into the ‘severe’ category

The study, conducted by a team of environmental health researchers from a leading Indian institute, analysed lung deposition patterns of major pollut-

ants such as PM2.5, PM10, black carbon, and toxic gases among male and female residents of the city. Using wearable air monitors and advanced lung-simulation models, the researchers measured how much pollution actually settles deep inside the lungs not just what people breathe in, but what stays inside the respiratory system. According to the findings, men showed a higher deposition fraction, meaning a larger per-

centage of pollutants inhaled were getting trapped inside their airways and alveoli. Scientists noted that this difference could be linked to biological and behavioural factors. Men typically have larger lung capacity and breathe more air per minute compared to women, which may increase the volume of pollutants entering their respiratory tract. Additionally, longer outdoor working hours, higher involve-

ment in activities such as driving, commuting, or physical labour, and more exposure to traffic emissions may be contributing to higher pollutant intake. Experts said that this higher deposition level can increase the risk of respiratory diseases such as asthma, chronic bronchitis, and reduced lung function. Prolonged exposure and high pollutant retention have also been associated with increased risk of heart disease and other long-term health complications. Doctors in Delhi have reported a rise in male patients complaining of persistent cough, chest tightness, and breathing discomfort, especially during peak pollution months from October to December.

Alarming Rise in Brain-Eating Amoeba Cases in Kerala: 170 Infections, 42 Deaths Reported in 2025

Dr. Rajnesh Kumar Pandey

Kerala has witnessed a startling surge in cases of amoebic meningoencephalitis, a rare but often fatal infection caused by free-living amoebae, with the State Government reporting 170 confirmed infections and 42 deaths in 2025, raising serious public health concerns. The figures were presented by authorities in Parliament on

December 5, 2025, which underscore one of the deadliest outbreaks of the so-called “brain-eating amoeba” in recent years. Amoebic meningoencephalitis is an acute infectious condition of the central nervous system most frequently caused by *Naegleria fowleri*, a microscopic organism found in warm, freshwater bodies such as lakes, ponds, wells,

and poorly chlorinated water. When water containing the amoeba enters the body through the nasal passages, it can rapidly migrate to the brain, leading to devastating inflammation and brain tissue destruction. The disease progresses swiftly, and global mortality rates for *Naegleria*-caused infections commonly exceed 95 percent. Public health au-

thorities in Kerala have attributed the rise in cases to a combination of environmental conditions, increased vigilance, and enhanced diagnostic capabilities. Warm weather, monsoon-related water stagnation, and

widespread presence of untreated freshwater bodies create favorable conditions for the amoebae to thrive. Unlike in previous years, when clusters of infections were linked to specific water sources, recent cases

appear as sporadic, geographically dispersed infections, complicating containment efforts. Health officials note that this pattern makes epidemiological tracking more challenging and necessitates widespread awareness and preventive measures. Experts stress that early detection and rapid treatment can improve survival chances. Kerala health authorities

have strengthened surveillance and clinical management, including training doctors to recognize symptoms such as high fever, severe headache, nausea, stiff neck, and neurological deterioration which can begin within days of exposure. Timely administration of anti-amoebic drugs such as miltefosine, combined with supportive care, has been credited

with helping some patients survive what is otherwise an overwhelmingly fatal condition. Kerala’s state health infrastructure has also expanded diagnostic capabilities, enabling rapid confirmation of amoebic infections. Improved laboratory testing has allowed quicker identification and intervention, potentially saving lives.

Centre proposes sending New Higher Education Bill to Joint Parliamentary Committee

Anjali Yadav

The Union government on 15th December 2025 proposed that the newly introduced Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishtan (VBSA) Bill, 2025, which aims to reform India’s higher education regulatory system, be referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) for detailed examination. The move came after strong objections were raised by several Opposition parties in Parliament. The Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan tabled the Bill in the Lok Sabha and described it as a major reform to modernise and simplify the governance of higher education in the country.

According to the government, the Bill seeks to replace the University Grants Commission (UGC), which has been in place for decades, and bring all higher education regulation under a single, streamlined framework. Under the proposed law, a new Higher Education Commission will be established as the apex body. It will be supported by three specialised councils, which will take over the roles currently performed by the UGC, the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE), and the National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE). The government said this structure will reduce duplication of work, improve coordination, and ensure better quality and innovation in higher education institutions. The Centre has also stated that the Bill will promote graded autonomy, allowing universities and colleges more freedom to grow based on their performance, academic strength, and capacity. However,

the Bill faced sharp criticism from Opposition members. Several MPs accused the government of “excessive centralisation” and argued that the proposed system gives too much control to the executive. They warned that strict compliance rules, heavy penalties, and provisions related to the closure of institutions could threaten

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Anjali Yadav

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Why are government school teachers protesting in Tamil Nadu?

Anjali Yadav

Government school teachers across Tamil Nadu have launched protests demanding correction of long-standing pay anomalies, bringing classrooms, district education offices and public spaces into focus. The agitation is largely led by Secondary Grade Teachers (SGTs), who say they have been unfairly paid lower salaries than their counterparts despite performing identical duties. The protests, which have intensified in recent

days, include sit-ins, demonstrations and plans for statewide strikes, drawing attention to unresolved grievances that have persisted for more than a decade. Teachers argue that the issue is not about fresh pay hikes but about restoring parity that was disrupted due to changes in pay scales introduced by the State government in 2009. As talks with the government have failed to produce a

concrete outcome so far, teacher associations say they have been left with no option but to take to the streets. **What is the pay anomaly teachers are protesting against?** The core of the protest lies in a pay revision implemented in 2009, under which Secondary Grade Teachers appointed after June 1 that year were

placed on a lower pay scale than those appointed earlier. This difference, teachers say, has no justification since qualifications, workload and responsibilities remain the same for both groups. Over time, successive pay commissions and annual increments have widened the gap, resulting in significant differences in monthly sala-

ries and retirement benefits. Teachers maintain that the principle of “equal pay for equal work” has been violated, and that repeated representations to successive governments have not led to a resolution. Many point out that court rulings and recommendations by expert committees have acknowledged the anomaly, yet administra-

UPSC to give preferred Exam Centres to candidates with disabilities

Samridhi

The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) has taken an important step to improve accessibility for candidates with benchmark disabilities (PwBD). The Commission has decided to allot the exam centre of choice to all PwBD candidates appearing for UPSC examinations. According to an official statement issued on December 12, 2025, this decision has been taken to address the special needs and practical difficulties faced by candidates with disabilities while appearing for competitive exams. Earlier, many PwBD candidates were unable to get their preferred examination centres because popular centres would

Himachal Pradesh bans mobile phones for students in schools

Anjali Yadav

The Himachal Pradesh government has announced a complete ban on students carrying mobile phones to school premises from pre-nursery to Class XII, starting from the upcoming academic session. Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu made the announcement on 13th December 2025, stating that the decision has been taken to improve discipline and focus among students. He clarified that the ban applies only to students, while teachers will be allowed to keep their mobile phones either in staff rooms or in their bags. The Chief Minister was speaking after inaugurating several

modern facilities at the Directorate of Samagra Shiksha in Shimla. These include the Vidya Samiksha Kendra (VSK), an Education Gallery, a Programme Management Studio Conference Area, a new Conference Hall, and a modern central heating system. Mr. Sukhu said that these state-of-the-art facilities will help strengthen both administrative and academic functioning. He added that they mark the beginning of a new phase of digital education governance in the State. Chief Minister also said that the State has significantly improved its performance at the national level. He noted that Himachal Pradesh has moved up

from the 21st position to the 5th position in education quality assessment rankings. He also added that Himachal Pradesh is among the leading States to adopt an integrated digital platform that provides real-time data on teaching processes, learning outcomes, and student attendance. According to him, such initiatives are helping improve transparency, monitoring, and overall quality of education in the State. The new mobile phone ban, along with the digital initiatives, is aimed at creating a better learning environment for students and strengthening the education system across Himachal Pradesh.

fill up quickly due to a high number of applicants. This often forced them to travel long distances, creating physical and logistical challenges. UPSC Chairman Ajay Kumar said that after studying examination centre data from the last five years, the Commission found that centres such as Delhi, Cuttack, Patna, Lucknow and several others reach full capacity very early. As a result, PwBD candidates were sometimes left with inconvenient

options. “With this new decision, every PwBD candidate will be assured of the examination centre they select in their application form. This will ensure greater comfort and ease while appearing for UPSC exams,” Mr. Kumar said. UPSC has introduced a new system to implement this decision. Initially the existing capacity of each examination centre will be filled by both PwBD and non-PwBD candidates. Once a centre

reaches its maximum capacity, it will no longer be available for selection by non-PwBD candidates. However, PwBD candidates will still be allowed to choose that centre. The Commission has also assured that it will create additional capacity at centres if required, so that no PwBD candidate is denied their preferred location. UPSC conducts several recruitment examinations for government services, including the highly competitive Civil Services Examination, which selects officers for the Indian Administrative Service (IAS), Indian Police Service (IPS), Indian Foreign Service (IFS), and other central services.

sions with teacher representatives and has stated that it is examining the issue. The School Education Department has acknowledged the grievance but has cited the financial implications of correcting the anomaly, which could involve thousands of teachers and a substantial outlay from the State exchequer. Ministers have assured that

a solution is being worked out, but no timeline has been announced. The protests carry political significance as the ruling party had, in the past, promised to address the pay disparity. With teachers forming a large and influential section of government employees, continued unrest could have implications for public education.

Kerala Government to screen All IFFK Films despite Centre’s Ban

Anjali Yadav

The Kerala government on 16th december 2025, announced that all films scheduled for screening at the 30th International Film Festival of Kerala (IFFK) will be shown as planned, a day after the Union Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (I&B) denied clearance to several movies.

Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan strongly criticised the Centre’s decision, calling it unacceptable and against creative freedom. In a statement, he said the move reflected the “autocratic tendencies” of the Sangh Parivar regime, which, according to

him, seeks to suppress diverse voices and artistic expression. “Kerala will not surrender to such censorship. All films denied permission will be screened at the festival,” he said.

The films initially denied clearance included Palestinian movies Palestine 36 and All That’s Left of You, the Soviet-era classic Battleship Potemkin, and Santosh, which highlights issues such as police brutality and caste discrimination. Also on the list were Timbuktu and Bamako by renowned filmmaker Abderrahmane Sissako, who is set to receive the IFFK Lifetime Achievement Award this year.

Minister for Cultural Affairs Saji Cherian also condemned the Centre’s action, calling it “undemocratic” and harmful to Kerala’s progressive art and cultural tradition. “Any attempt to destroy the spirit and legacy of this festival cannot be accepted. The government will continue to take a firm stand in defence of

artistic freedom,” he said. The Minister also pointed out that all 19 films denied clearance were internationally recognised and had been widely appreciated by audiences across the world. He added that the rights of film festival delegates to watch these movies could not be denied, especially as the films were already listed

in the official festival schedule and hand-book circulated earlier. Meanwhile, the protests erupted at the main festival venue, Tagore Theatre, on Monday night (15th December 2025). Members of the Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) staged demonstrations against the I&B Ministry’s decision, accusing the Centre of imposing censorship on cinema. In a partial reversal, the I&B Ministry on Tuesday morning granted clearance to five of the 19 films that were earlier barred. The films that received approval are Beef, Eagles of the Republic, Heart of the Wolf, Yes, and Once Upon a Time in Gaza.

Dhurandhar Box Office Day 14: Film crosses ₹450 Crore, strong run continues

Bhavya Aneja

Aditya Dhar’s action spy film Dhurandhar, starring Ranveer Singh, continues to perform impressively at the box office. Released in theatres on December 5, the film has shown no major slowdown even in its second week and has crossed the ₹450 crore mark within 14 days.

Box Office Performance

As per trade reports from Sacnilk, Dhurandhar earned ₹21.78 crore on its second Thursday. With this, the film’s total domestic collection has reached ₹459.03 crore net in India. The movie collected ₹207.25 crore in its first week and has done even better in its

second week, earning over ₹240 crore so far. What stands out is its steady performance, with daily earnings staying strong and showing very little drop throughout the second week.

Dhurandhar achieved the ₹200 crore milestone in just five days, surpassing Pushpa 2, which collected ₹196.50 crore in Hindi in seven days during its second week. The film has also gone past the

second-week collections of major hits like Pathaan (₹446.2 crore) and Gadar 2 (₹419.1 crore).

About the Film: This film is written, directed, and co-produced by Aditya Dhar, Dhurandhar features a powerful cast including Ranveer Singh, Akshaye Khanna, R Madhavan, Arjun Rampal, Sanjay Dutt, Sara Arjun, and Rakesh Bedi in key roles.

Sunny Deol’s Patriotic Message Steals the Show at Border 2 Teaser Launch

Bhavya Aneja

Veteran actor Sunny Deol set a strong patriotic tone at the grand teaser launch of Border 2 in Mumbai, speaking emotionally about nationalism, responsibility, and the bond between generations. At the event, Deol said he has complete faith in today’s youth, especially Gen Z.

He shared that young people are just as devoted to the nation as earlier generations. According to him, love for the country does not fade with time or change with labels, it is passed down through families and values. Talking about what patriotism means to him, Deol described the nation as a mother figure.

He explained that this feeling is timeless and lives equally in the hearts of the young and the old. He added that if the situation ever demands it, today’s youth would stand up to protect and honour the country just as their parents and grandparents once did. The atmosphere turned deeply emotional when Sunny Deol delivered his famous dialogue

from Border, “Awaaz kahan tak jaani chahiye? Lahore tak.” His trembling voice and teary eyes moved the audience, who responded with loud applause and cheers. This was Deol’s first public professional appearance after the passing of his father, legendary actor Dharmendra, which made the moment even more emotional. The teas-

er launch was held on Vijay Diwas, further strengthening the patriotic mood of the event. The launch also saw the presence of the film’s lead actors Varun Dhawan, Ahan Shetty, and Diljit Dosanjh, symbolising a mix of experience and youth an idea that reflects the film’s core theme.

About the Film: This movie is directed by Anurag Singh, Border 2 carries forward the legacy of the 1997 hit Border, which was based on the Battle of Longewala during the 1971 India–Pakistan war. The sequel draws inspiration from the same historic events and aims to present a powerful story of bravery, sacrifice, and love for the nation.

Famous Bollywood director “Vikram Bhatt Arrested in Fraud Case

Tisha Taneja

Vikram Bhatt known for films like Raaz and 1920 has been arrested in a 30 crore fraud case he has been sent to Udaipur Central Jail .after a local court rejected his bail. The case has created attention in both the film industry and the business community.

According to the police Vikram Bhatt and his wife shweta bari bhatt and some others people are accused of cheating on a businessman from udaipur Dr. Ajay Murdia. The businessman said he was asked to invest money for making a biopic film based on his late ex-wife. He was reportedly promised good profits from the project and was assured that the film would be made on a

large scale. The businessman claimed that he invested a large amount of money after trusting the filmmakers. The film was never made. Dr. Murdia further alleged that fake bills and false documents were shown to him to make it look like the money was being used for film production. When he realized that he had been cheated, he approached the police. A FIR was registered on November 17 at Bhopal pura police station in Udaipur. Vikram Bhatt was arrested from Mumbai and brought to Udaipur for questioning. After police custody ended , Vikram Bhatt and his wife were produced in court. Their lawyer asked for Bail on the medical ground but the court rejected the request. The court then ordered that both be sent to judicial custody. The police investigation in the case is still going on. They are examining financial records, bank

transactions, and documents related to the alleged film project. The role of other accused persons is also being investigated. This case has once again highlighted the importance of transparency and trust in business dealings, especially in the film industry where large investments are involved. Further details are expected to come out as the investigation progresses.

Brigitte Bardot, Legendary French Film Icon and Influential Animal Rights Advocate, Dies at 91

Anjali Yadav

Brigitte Bardot, one of the most iconic figures of 20th-century cinema and a defining symbol of French culture, has died at the age of 91, her long-time animal welfare foundation announced. Bardot, whose beauty and magnetism revolutionised international screen stardom in the 1950s and 1960s, passed away at her beloved home in Saint-Tropez on December 28, 2025, after a battle with cancer, her husband Bernard d’Ormale confirmed

to the press. Born on September 28, 1934, in Paris, Bardot first captured global attention with her breakout role in And God Created Woman (1956), directed by then-husband Roger Vadim. The film propelled her to international fame, establishing her as the quintessential embodiment of liberated femininity and sparking a wave of new attitudes toward sexuality and personal freedom.

Over her two-decade film career, she appeared in dozens of productions, earning

widespread admiration for her performances and on-screen presence.

After retiring from acting in 1973 at the height of her popularity, Bardot turned her considerable influence toward animal rights.

In 1986 she founded the Brigitte Bardot Foundation, dedicating her life, resources, and celebrity to campaigning against cruelty to animals worldwide. Her activism drew both praise and controversy, from protests

against seal hunting and bullfighting to criticism of laboratory animal testing.

Bardot’s efforts made her a powerful voice for animal welfare and helped raise global awareness of en-

dangered species and inhumane practices. Saint-Tropez, where Bardot remained a polarising figure in her later years. Alongside her advocacy, she expressed outspoken views on political and social issues that attracted criticism and led to several legal convictions in France for comments deemed as inciting racial hatred. Despite the controversies, her impact on film and public discourse was undeniable.

Thousands of mourners and fans paid tribute to Bardot’s memory at a funeral service

held January 7 in a lasting imprint on French culture. Tributes have poured in from around the world, highlighting her revolutionary influence on cinema and her tireless commitment to the voiceless creatures she championed.

Brigitte Bardot’s life was a tapestry of glamour, defiance, and compassion. She will be remembered not only as a screen icon but as a complex and courageous figure who lived boldly on her own terms.

French President Emmanuel Macron paid homage to Bardot on social media, describing her as “a legend of the century” whose films and activism left

India Beat South Africa 3-1 to Win Five-Match T20I Series

Anjali Yadav

India defeated South Africa 3–1 in the five-match T20 International series after winning the fifth and final match on Thursday (December 18 2025). One match ended with no result due to bad weather. The series saw strong performances from Indian batters and bowlers, helping the home team dominate most of the games. India began the series with a commanding victory in the first T20 match, where the team put up an impressive batting

IPL Auction: Prithvi Shaw, Sarfaraz Khan's IPL exile ends; Cameron Green makes history

Anjali Yadav

IPL Auction: Kolkata Knight Riders splurged a record-breaking Rs 25.20 to land top Australian all-rounder Cameron Green even as Indian stars Prithvi Shaw and Sarfaraz Khan went unsold in the Indian Premier League players' auction on Tuesday (December 16 2025). The franchise kept the momentum going, investing heavily again to secure Matheesha Pathirana for INR 18 crore, bolstering their pace attack with one of the most sought-after



display. The Indian bowlers then bowled out South Africa for a low total, securing a big win and taking a 1-0 lead in the series. The match showed India's depth in both batting and bowling. South Africa bounced back strongly in the second T20. Their batters played aggressive shots and posted a challenging total. India struggled during the chase and lost wickets regularly. South Africa won the match comfortably, leveling the series 1-1 and keeping the contest alive. In the third T20, India regained control of the series. The Indian bowlers struck early

young fast bowlers in the circuit. Venkatesh Iyer, however, witnessed a sharp correction in his valuation. RCB snapped him up for INR7 crore, and while KKR did enter the bidding for their former player, they pulled out early this time, a stark contrast to the fierce pursuit that defined his price tag last season. CSK stole the show on the domestic front, breaking the bank for Prashant Veer and Kartik Sharma at INR 14.2 crore each. Their signings not only made them the costliest Indian buys of the day but also saw both players create history as the joint most expensive uncapped picks the auction has ever seen. Delhi Capitals, meanwhile, showed clear intent by investing INR 8.4 crore in Aqib Nabi Dar, backing the youngster as a long-term prospect. The business picked up pace late in the day with overseas names back in demand. Sunrisers Hyderabad secured power-hitter Liam Livingstone for INR 13 crore, adding firepower to their middle order. Bangladesh

and restricted South Africa to a manageable score. The batters then chased the target calmly and won the match without much trouble. This win gave India a 2-1 lead in the series. The fourth T20 match could not be completed due to fog and poor visibility. Match officials decided to abandon the game for safety reasons, and no result was declared. With one match remaining, India stayed ahead in the series. The fifth and final T20 proved decisive. Batting first, India posted a big total with aggressive innings

nds; Cameron Green makes history

pacer Mustafizur Rahman also commanded big money, emerging as one of the most expensive overseas bowlers at INR 9.2 crore. Uncapped Indian players continued to enjoy a bumper day as well, with Salil Arora earning nearly five times his base price and Mangesh Yadav attracting an INR 5.2 crore deal, capping off an auction dominated by bold spends and record-breaking numbers. Prithvi Shaw also got late buyers in his old franchise, Delhi Capitals, as they signed him in the third attempt

from Hardik Pandya and Tilak Varma. South Africa tried to keep up during the chase, but India's bowlers maintained pressure and took crucial wickets at regular intervals. India won the match and sealed the series 3-1. Overall, India showed better consistency and teamwork throughout the series. The young players performed well along with experienced cricketers. South Africa fought hard but could not match India in key moments. The series win ended on a positive note for India and cricket fans

in this auction for INR 75 Lakh. Kyle Jamieson was the last player to get sold in the auction with DC picking him for INR 2 crore. Speaking with jio hotstar anil kamble quoted "I would like to see him play the opening slot for KKR. I think, in terms of a finisher, KKR already have a decent line-up. I don't think they utilised their resources well last season. Yes, of course, Shreyas Iyer, the skipper, was missing and Mitchell Starc, the key fast bowler, was also missing," he said.

Lionel Messi winds up G.O.A.T. India Tour with Delhi leg

Anjali Yadav

The Lionel Messi G.O.A.T. India Tour that began in sham-bolic fashion ended in a blaze of glory as devotional fans joyously gathered to catch a glimpse of a man that does things on the field that are often beyond human comprehension. Most importantly, the much publicized and anticipated event had the ending it wanted, after a chaotic beginning in Kolkata on the tour's first stop on Saturday.

On December 15 2025 thousands of heads totting the stands at Kotla, as well as the few Indian celebrities and dignitaries inside the ground, basked in the euphoria of hosting one of the world's most recognizable and bankable athletes at an extravagant event. They were perhaps swept away by the otherworldly talent, the humility, and the impact that this man

Mentor Over Protege: Anand Outplays World Champion Gukesh as Ganges Grandmasters Crush PBG Alaskan Knights

Anjali Yadav

World Champion loses to his mentor in another disappointing result as Ganges Grandmasters beat PBG Alaskan Knights Sicilian opening, a razor-sharp option which sends a signal to the opponent that you're itching for a battle over the 64 squares. That's exactly what world champion D Gukesh did when he faced off against his idol and mentor Viswanathan Anand in a Global Chess League clash on December 16 2025. Anand might be semi-retired, but he hasn't lost his appetite for a good fight

Jacob Duffy: From a 530-Person Town to No.1 T20I Bowler and an IPL Deal

Samridhi

The town in New Zealand's Southland has a population of only 530 people that is one person every 117 square kilometres. One of them is the highest ranked fast bowler in the world, Jacob Duffy. Now, he has an IPL contract too, worth Rs 2 crore and the most famous Lumsdean cricketer would play in the same side as the most famous active

and forced his protegee to resign in 45 moves as his team Ganges Grandmasters defeated the teenage world champion's PBG Alaskan Knights 12-3. The Sicilian Defence, the weapon of choice for the sport's most ferocious fighters like Garry Kasparov and Bobby Fischer, starts off by responding to white's 1.e4 with a push of the black's c

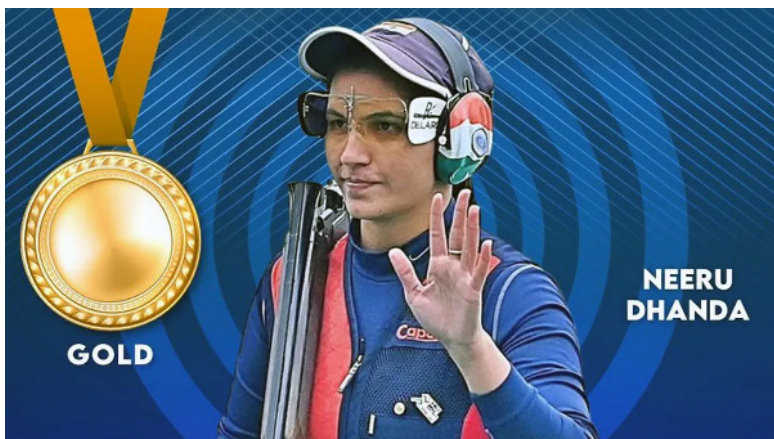
Indian cricketer, Virat Kohli. Duffy's name did not set the auction table on fire. He was sold for his entry price. RCB might sense a bargain, because he is arguably the most consistent T20 bowler in the last two years, once even climbing to the top of the chart. He is chiseled in Josh Hazlewood mould. He doesn't bowl with explosive pace, but possesses a staggering control of lines. He

pawn to c5 rather than the more preferred response with the e or d pawns. The idea behind the Sicilian is to break the symmetry in the centre and destabilise the position. It almost always leads to a sharp fight. Gukesh not only opted for a fight against the man he calls ‘Vishy sir’, but chose to play the Kan Variation of the Sicilian, thus trying to give the man who got the teenager dreaming about becoming world champion someday a flashback to the 2014 World Championship match against Magnus Carlsen.

is brisk, blessed with dexterity in length, has adequate though no cryptic variations, has a heavy ball and can swing the ball both ways in favourable conditions. The T20I numbers are terrific; 53 wickets in 38 games, striking every 14th ball and leaking only 7.34. The 31-year-old, self-admittedly, is a limited bowler. But from childhood, he has a gift of conquering limitations.

Neeru Dhanda wins women's trap gold at National Shooting Championship

Asian Championship gold medalist Neeru Dhanda delivered a composed performance to win the women's trap gold at the 68th National Shooting Championships (Shotgun) on December 29, at the Dr Karni Singh Shooting Range in Delhi.



Neeru finished on top with 41 hits in the final, holding off a strong challenge from Delhi's Kirti Gupta, who settled for silver with 40. Neeru's state teammate from Madhya Pradesh, Pragati Dubey, completed the podium with bronze after scoring 32 hits. The junior men's trap final saw Aryavansh Tyagi rise to the occasion with a strong finish, shooting 42 to win gold. Punjab's Keshav Chauhan took silver with 37, while Uttar Pradesh's Zuhair Khan claimed bronze with 30. Zuhair Khan

had earlier dominated the qualification round with a score of 120, ahead of Aryan Singh's 118, who finished fifth in the final with 21 hits. Aryavansh Tyagi and Arjun both shot 115, with Aryavansh advancing on a shoot-off. Keshav Chauhan (113) and Manitwal Singh Rawat (112) completed the list of finalists. Manitwal finished fourth with 27, while Arjun of Haryana ended sixth with 14 hits.

In the team events, Madhya Pradesh dominated the women's trap team competition, winning gold with a

combined total of 339 from Pragati Dubey, Neeru Dhanda and Manisha Keer. Delhi secured silver with 333 through Addya Katyal, Kirti Gupta and Bhavya Tripathi, while Punjab claimed bronze with 319 from Rajeshwari Kumari, Pukhraj Kaur Chahal and Krishika Joshi.

Haryana claimed the junior men's trap team gold with an aggregate score of 336, courtesy of Arjun, Lakshya Atree and Prikshit Arya. Gujarat finished second with 327 from Aryan Singh, Bakhtyar Uddin Mohamadmuzahid

and Manavrajsinh Rajendrasinh Chudasma, while Rajasthan secured bronze with 326 through Udhav Singh Rathore, Prithviraj Singh Rathore and Vinay Pratap Singh C.

Delhi won the junior women's trap team gold, as Addya Katyal, Bhavya Tripathi and Ananya Yaduvanshi combined for a winning total of 323. Tamil Nadu finished second with 295, while Rajasthan took bronze with 274.

publicized and anticipated event had the ending it wanted, after a chaotic beginning in Kolkata on the tour's first stop on Saturday.

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has had on the game he has played with all his might over the last two decades. Speaking briefly in Spanish a language not spoken by most in the city, Messi said, "Gracias Delhi! Hasta pronto", creating a sense of yearn-

ing among the crowds rarely seen before. Upon arrival, Messi took a lap of the ground smiling, and watched the 7x7 celebrity match coming to an end, even as the spectators, many of whom were dressed in the famous blue

and white Argentine jersey bearing No. 10, chanted his name continuously. He was then standing there waving to the stands smiling, something he tried to do in Kolkata too but could not as, unlike the Arun Jaitley Stadium, he was crowded by too many people, including politicians and their aides, at the Salt Lake Stadium on Saturday. Messi also felicitated the Minerva Academy football team. The script was specifically written for Messi, and, as is his wont, he played the role to perfection. Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, ICC Chairman Jay Shah, DDCA President Rohan Jaitley and former Indian football team captain Bhaichung Bhutia had the privilege to be with Messi towards the end of the 30-minute event. Indian Football star Sunil Chettari honored him with a football jersey to mark the end of the ceremony.

